

NICHOLAS BECKER

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I am software engineer with 9 years of specialized experience in IBM z/OS development, specifically within the JES2 (Job Entry Subsystem 2) component of the operating system. My career progression ranges from dedicated testing to senior development, mastering mainframe programming languages including HLASM, PL/X, and metal C. I have a proven track record of reducing system defects, decreasing on-boarding time for new team members, and uncovering and patching critical security vulnerabilities in operating system code. I am recognized as a top-tier technical leader, being selected to attend the exclusive IBM Tech conference in 2023. After a deliberate career break to focus on family, personal well-being, and self-reflection, I am fully recharged and eager to return to a senior software engineering role.

CORE COMPETENCIES & TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming Languages: IBM HLASM, IBM PL/1, IBM Metal C, ISPF/REXX, Python, Javascript

Other Languages: JCL, JSON, YAML, HTML, CSS, XML

Operating Systems: z/OS, z/VM, CMS, UNIX-based OS's, Consumer OS's

Specialized Tools: MVS/JCL utilities, ISPF, IPCS, SDSF, zACS and zACM, UNIX Tools and Utilities

Disciplines: Full Lifecycle Software Development, Root Cause Analysis, Security Auditing, Technical Instruction

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

The Magic Mainframe, LLC | Cedar Rapids, IA

Freelance Information Technology Consultant

March 2024 – Present

- Founded an independent consulting venture to provide IBM Z mainframe expertise to mainframe clients.
- Offered specialized technical advisory services in z/OS, JES2, and HLASM.
- Developed client proposals and scoped technical projects or potential engagements.
- Maintained current knowledge of mainframe and enterprise trends.

IBM Corporation | Rochester, MN

Advisory Software Engineer

May 2021 – June 2024

- Technical leadership role with a 60% development and 40% testing workload.
- Spearheaded complex defect resolution and mentored the next generation of mainframe engineers within a 15-person team.
- Improved system stability by reducing the active APAR backlog from about 100 APARS to an average of 45 APARs by prioritizing, developing, and testing high-impact fixes for field-reported issues.
- Developed functional enhancements to JES2 based on customer feedback and to address requirements generated internally at IBM.
- Frequent presenter at IBM technical forums, delivering complex technical briefings to global service and support teams.

Staff Software Engineer

Feb 2017 – May 2021

- Balanced a 75% testing and 25% development workload, bridging the gap between quality assurance and operating system development.
- Performed rigorous function and regression testing for JES2 functions, ensuring high-quality releases in a complex z/OS environment.
- Utilized and mastered specialized tools like IPCS and SDSF for deep-dive problem determination, analyzing system dumps and traces to isolate system-level defects.
- Transitioned from dedicated testing into active development, building proficiency in HLASM, PL/X, and metal C.

Software Engineer

June 2015 – February 2017

- Developed and executed comprehensive test plans for JES2 functions, identifying defects early in the development cycle.
- Collaborated closely with development teams and testing team lead to reproduce, isolate, and test fixes for field-reported issues.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

United States Postal Service | Cedar Rapids, IA

City Mail Carrier

July 2025 – Present

- Safely and efficiently delivered mail and parcels to communities in the Cedar Rapids, IA area in the extreme weather conditions of the Midwest.
- Took on a role outside of technology to gain perspective, recharge, and reflect on my engineering career.
- Solidified my commitment to returning to software engineering with renewed focus, patience, and a refined approach to problem solving.

EDUCATION

University of Iowa | Iowa City, IA

B.S. Mathematics and Computer Science

Aug 2011 – May 2015

- Awards: Advantage Iowa Scholar, Dean's List
- GPA: 3.21
- Advanced Coursework: Programming Language Concepts, Operating Systems, Theory of Computation, Artificial Intelligence, Compiler Construction
- Tutoring: Tutored students in fundamental and intermediate courses in mathematics and computer science.

IBM Master the Mainframe Competition

Prize Winner

Spring 2012, 2013, 2014

- Participated in a nationwide competition among high school and college students.
- Introduced to enterprise computing systems and applied theoretical knowledge acquired while studying computer science.